The Myanmar port of Pegu emerged as a major shipbuilding centre, and ships built there were also very large in size. Early Portuguese accounts suggest that as late as the sixteenth century, Chinese silk and porcelain from Ayutthia would be carried to the ports of Mergui and Martaban loaded on elephants. The ships for the passage to India had to be large enough to hold not only export goods but also two or three elephants, which were in high demand in Indian royal kingdoms, since local supply had dwindled with the shrinking forest habitats of this large, highly prized animal. For the return journey the ships would carry a variety of Indian goods to the same ports for transhipment to China through Ayutthia.

The route which became progressively more important was the one through ports in South-East Asia, including Malacca, Palembang and Kedah (in Malaysia). But Indian ports themselves served as trade emporia in the larger circuit of trade between China and the Persian Gulf, Arabia, Africa and the eastern Mediterranean. These were the ports of Cambay on the Gujarat coast, Calicut and Quilon (Kollam) on the Malabar coast and Nagapattinam on the Coromandel coast. During the first half of the second millennium, Chinese silk, porcelain, copper, quicksilver, tin and lead were exported to Indian ports and some of the items were re-exported to countries in the Persian Gulf, along the coasts of Arabia and Africa. Goods brought from these regions and Indian items agglomerated at these Indian ports included Indian pepper and spices, coconut and areca nut, precious gems, fine cotton fabrics, aromatics from Arabia and Africa, and horses from Central Asia.

Trade between ancient China and the Roman empire was also mediated by India. Chinese silk and other luxury items traversed the oasis towns of Central Asia on caravans, with one branch moving into northern and western India and another headed towards Persia. Goods coming into India through the land route would then be transhipped west from the Indian ports of Bharrukacha (modern Bharuch) on the Gujarat coast and the famous port of Muziris on the Malabar coast. Fine Indian muslin cloth with its near-transparent texture was perhaps more highly prized in Rome than Chinese silk.